

Arlington County Board meeting will mark 20 years since death of chairman on dais

by SCOTT McCaffrey, Sun Gazette Newspapers
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The January meeting of the Arlington County Board marks the 20th anniversary of one of the sadder moments in local governance.

It was at the County Board's January meeting in 2003 that Democratic board member Charles Monroe, who was slated to serve as chair for the year, collapsed and died early in the meeting.

A massive stroke was the cause of death of the 46-year-old at the meeting, which was being held on Jan. 11, 2003.

Monroe, an attorney with deep family roots in Arlington, in the spring of 1999 had lost a special election to Republican Mike Lane to fill the remaining months of the term of County Board member Al Eisenberg. Eisenberg had resigned to take a political post in the Clinton administration.

Despite the loss in the special election, Monroe bounced back in November 1999 to win one of two County Board seats on the ballot that year. He and fellow Democrat Paul Ferguson defeated Lane and Republican Frances Finta.

In late 2002, Monroe was tapped by his board colleagues to serve as chair for 2003, in anticipation of a re-election run later that year.

In the subsequent special election to fill Monroe's seat, Democrat Walter Tejada won the post, which he would hold until 2015.

Eisenberg, whose resignation set off the sequence of events in 1999, died late last year.

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